



Review

Reviewed Work(s): Thomas Aquinas' Trinitarian Theology: A Study in Theological Method by Timothy L. Smith

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historically questionable notion of a fixed frontier defense in stasis from the Severans to the Islamic conquest.

On social archaeology: Perusal of published field reports would allow an examination of the cultural geography of Ghassānland irrespective of inscriptions. It may be possible to discern a landscape imprint (e.g., unusual prosperity and a building boom) that fits like a GIS layer over the zone of phylarchic authority precisely enough to call it an instance of Ghassānid culture. Unless such Ghassānid sociocultural cohesiveness of the residents of the region is demonstrated, the term “Ghassānland” remains a modern contrivance imposed on the ancient landscape.

I hope these four approaches will help in the archaeological construction of a cultural context for the court poetry to be treated in the next part of this volume.

In quoting the poet Ṭarafa’s simile of the Byzantine bridge “raised up true” (p. 75) as evidence that Byzantine architecture was admired in Arabia, Shahîd does not mention that this simile described the muscular neck of Ṭarafa’s swift-riding camel—a beautiful example of the interpenetration of the desert and the sown! I hope that the future installments will furnish more copious quotations to allow such contexts into the evidence.

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TIMOTHY L. SMITH, *Thomas Aquinas’ Trinitarian Theology: A Study in Theological Method*. Washington, D.C.: Catholic University of America Press, 2003. Pp. xiii, 258; 1 black-and-white figure and 1 diagram. \$59.95.

Timothy L. Smith’s *Thomas Aquinas’ Trinitarian Theology* is a model work in historical theology and philosophy, simultaneously showing a deep understanding of Thomas’s medieval context and a sensitivity to contemporary theological issues. The work is intended to be primarily historical, but the presentation is deeply relevant to contemporary questions. This enjoyable and enlightening book is written with a clarity most admirable in a study of very difficult parts of Thomas’s thought that are central to our understanding of both his theology and his philosophy. It should be read by anyone interested in Aquinas or Trinitarian doctrine, whether within a medieval or a contemporary context.

Smith opens by examining the stereotyped division within Trinitarian theology between the “Latin approach,” which starts with the unity of the divine substance and proceeds to the threeness of Persons, and the opposite “Greek approach.” Thomas, it is said, was a representative of the Latin tradition, though eventually Smith will challenge this through a comparison between Thomas and Augustine. Moreover, theologians like Karl Rahner find the Latin tradition theologically objectionable, despite the fact, one might note, that it follows the historical order in which revelation was given. The worry for the critics of the Latin tradition is that the doctrine of the Trinity is just tacked on to a belief in God and is irrelevant to the Christian life. Rahner more specifically fears that Thomas’s insistence that the Persons always act together vis-à-vis creatures (in the *opera ad extra*) makes it impossible for the Persons also to form an economic Trinity.

Smith tells us that some theologians have even criticized Thomas for having a different subject of discussion in questions 2–26 from that in questions 27–43 of the *prima pars*, the “one God” and “the Triune God,” respectively. This kind of a misreading, Smith holds, is inspired by Cajetan’s suggestion that “we can speak of ‘God’ to indicate the divine Persons and ‘this God’ to indicate the ‘individual’ divine nature” (p. 43). The subject of questions 2–26 would be the divine essence considered as an individual, a *this*, while 27–43 are concerned with God as the divine Persons, which easily leads to the heresy of supposing the essence to be a fourth item, beyond the three Persons. Against this, Smith argues that for Thomas, the “identity of essence and supposita in God means that there is

nothing other than Persons in God" (p. 43, emphasis added). Thus, the three Persons are always already on the scene in the text, though "Thomas treats the Godhead as a whole before treating it according to its parts using a type of abstraction" (p. 46). A minor difficulty in Smith's emphasis is that it appears to make the identity between the essence and the Persons a reduction of the former to the latter, whereas the identity seems to be more symmetric in Thomas.

Smith's argument gathers further force in the second chapter where, *inter alia*, he carefully examines the way terms become more precise as one proceeds through the Trinitarian questions in the *Summa theologiae*. It is only in question 39 that the full meaning of "essence" becomes clear through various distinctions. This is exactly what we would expect if the questions on God as one dealt with God via an abstractive procedure: insofar as one is dealing with an abstraction, some distinctions become irrelevant.

Smith's enlightening discussion of the specifics of Thomas's Trinitarian terminology and grammar in the second and third chapters is of deep independent interest, apart from general methodological questions. It is not possible to do justice to this elegant discussion in this short review, but it should be read by anyone interested in Thomas's metaphysics or Trinitarian theology.

In his conclusions at the end of the discussion of Trinitarian theology, Smith comes back to Rahner's criticisms by noting that the "doctrine of the unity of divine works (*opera ad extra*) does not deny that one divine Person acts in a peculiar way. This doctrine denies that such acts are done without the other two and that they offer any insight into the proper identity of any one of the divine Persons" (p. 108). It is worth reflecting on this brief but insightful remark in conjunction with Thomas's observation that the Word "is intelligent, not as producing a Word, but as the Word proceeding; forasmuch as in God the Word proceeding does not differ really from the divine intellect, but is distinguished from the principle of the Word only by relation" (I.35.2, *ad* 3, Fathers of the English Dominican Province translation). A parallel of this observation for the *opera ad extra* might allow that Smith is right: while these works are each fully wrought by each of the Persons, we can say that the Father does the work *as* the one productive of the Word and *as* co-spirating the Spirit; the Son does it *as* the Word produced and *as* co-spirating the Spirit; and the Holy Spirit does it *as* the Spirit spirated. The difference entirely supervenes on the eternal relations within the Trinity in the sense that the assertion that, say, "The Son in creating acts as the Word proceeding" is to be decomposed into a conjunction of two assertions, the first entirely dealing with the eternal internal relations ("The Son is the Word proceeding"), the second dealing entirely with the effect produced and mentioning each of the Persons in the same way ("The world is created by the Son [or by the Father, or by the Spirit]").

Smith rounds out his study by showing that the frequently made connection between Thomas and the speculative grammarians of his time has no evidential basis and then proceeding to an analysis of Thomas's views of religious language and the connection between Thomas and Pseudo-Dionysius. Smith argues that Pseudo-Dionysius, or a particular interpretation of him that Smith conjectures is that of St. Albert, is in fact cited primarily in the objections parts of Thomas's discussion of divine names in the *Summa theologiae*. Thomas believes we can name God in a way that goes beyond pure negation and mere stating of the effects of God's action, the way of eminence. The statement "God is good" is a statement not only that God produces good things but also that God is that in virtue of which God produces good things. Of course, we cannot *understand* that in virtue of which God produces good things—that would require understanding God's essence—but we can meaningfully *refer* to it in our language. And in that sense we can say more than we can understand on Thomas's view, Smith argues. One might illustrate this by noting that we used the word "heat" to successfully refer to that in virtue of which various phe-

nomena, such as certain bodily sensations and changes of food flavor, were produced before we had any understanding of what heat was—that it was the kinetic energy of molecules. Moreover, when one said that x had heat, one did not just deny something of x , or merely say that x produced these phenomena, but one affirmed of x that x had that something in virtue of which it produced these phenomena, without one's understanding that "something."

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FIONA SOMERSET, JILL C. HAVENS, and DERRICK G. PITARD, eds., *Lollards and Their Influence in Late Medieval England*. Woodbridge, Eng., and Rochester, N.Y.: Boydell and Brewer, 2003. Pp. x, 344; black-and-white figures and 1 map.

This collection of thirteen essays plus an extensive set of bibliographic essays is a stimulating and diverse guide to Lollard studies at present, including some brilliant pieces of close reading, a series of provocative arguments, and an array of critical and historiographical surveys. To gather such a range of work, and of a quality that is generally very high, is a major accomplishment, and the book will surely be a new lodestone in the field. But specialists in Lollardy will likely find this collection more provocative than they might assume from the title, the section headings, or the introduction, and those turning to it as an introduction to Lollardy will no doubt sense a field moving in exciting but rather unpredictable ways.

Four section headings group the essays: "Lollards in the Wind," "Lollard Thought," "Lollards and Their Books," and "Heresy, Dissidence, and Reform," which define, as Fiona Somerset says in her introduction, "the fundamental, longstanding questions in the field" (p. 10): respectively, who the Lollards were, what they believed, how those beliefs were disseminated, and how such ideas were related to other contemporary views. Like the book's title, the section headings might have come straight from Anne Hudson's monumental *Premature Reformation: Wycliffite Texts and Lollard History* (Oxford, 1988). It was Hudson who asked how we can identify a text as Lollard, how "adherence to beliefs associated with Wyclif affect[ed] the lives, the education, and the reading" of a far-flung range of individuals, how such ideas were disseminated, how coherently they were sustained, and what their relationship was to contemporary conventional piety (*Premature Reformation*, p. 6).

Hudson's work has always been predicated on such "fundamental" questions, but her own forceful and well-supported answers have shaped the field for a generation, making titles like those structuring the present collection specifically meaningful and promising a recognizable range of materials. Hudson's depth and range of learning, and her brisk grasp of the features essential for her project, have established a general sense that Wycliffite ideas, religious commitments, turns of phrase, and even clothing can be defined and traced fairly securely. Her codicologically based intellectual history has highlighted a web of "Wycliffite texts and Lollard history" into an entwined but vivid skein that may lead, and surely has led, many nonspecialists to think that she both posed the modern terms of this field and finished their broad definitions. And from the title and subheadings of this book, we might assume that there are few dissenters to the major assumptions about the field. In her brief preface Hudson mentions Eamon Duffy, who believes that Lollardy's significance has been generally overestimated in late-medieval religious culture, and Paul Strohm, who argues that Lollardy was largely the invention of the Lancastrian regime for its own purposes. While Hudson only minimally notes them by name, she spends much of her pithy preface rejecting their views, maintaining what might be considered the core elements of her perspective: that Lollardy certainly seemed significant to contemporaries as a wide-